

Automated Breast Cancer Detection Using Attention-Based CNN

Aakriti Shory
Chitkara University Institute of
Engineering and Technology
Chitkara University
Punjab, India
aakritishory15@gmail.com

Bhoomika
Chitkara University Institute of
Engineering and Technology
Chitkara University
Punjab, India
bhoomikamittal11@gmail.com

Harshit
Chitkara University Institute of
Engineering and Technology Chitkara
University
Punjab, India
harshitgahlawat2004@gmail.com

Isha Kansal
Chitkara University Institute of
Engineering and Technology Chitkara
University
Punjab, India
isha.kansal@chitkara.edu.in

Abstract—Breast cancer remains one of the leading causes of cancer-related mortality among women worldwide, making early and accurate detection critical for improving survival rates. Conventional diagnostic methods relying on manual interpretation of medical images such as mammograms and ultrasounds are often challenged by variations in tumor characteristics, including shape, size, and density, as well as imaging noise, leading to diagnostic inconsistencies. This study proposes an advanced deep learning-based framework for automated breast cancer detection using an attention-based CNN integrated with transfer learning. The methodology involves preprocessing steps such as normalization, resizing, contrast enhancement, and data augmentation to improve model robustness. A pre-trained CNN model is fine-tuned to extract high-level features, while an attention mechanism focuses on tumor-relevant regions and suppresses background noise. The extracted features are processed using Global Average Pooling and fully connected layers for binary classification. The model is evaluated using accuracy, precision, recall, F1-score, and AUC. Experimental results demonstrate improved performance over conventional CNN models with better sensitivity and specificity. The proposed framework provides a reliable computer-aided diagnostic system that enhances early detection and supports clinical decision-making.

Keywords: Breast Cancer Detection, Deep Learning, CNN, Attention Mechanism, Medical Image Analysis

I. INTRODUCTION

Breast cancer is one of the most prevalent cancers affecting women globally and remains a leading cause of cancer-related mortality. Early detection plays a critical role in increasing survival rates and enabling effective treatment planning. Medical imaging techniques such as mammography, ultrasound, and histopathological analysis are widely used for diagnosis; however, manual interpretation of these images is often time-consuming, subjective, and prone to human error, leading to inconsistencies in diagnosis.

In recent years, the integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in healthcare has transformed medical image analysis. Deep

learning techniques, particularly (CNNs), have demonstrated remarkable success in automatically extracting complex features and achieving high classification accuracy. These models eliminate the need for manual feature engineering and provide a scalable solution for large-scale medical data processing. Despite these advancements, conventional CNN-based models face certain limitations. They process the entire image uniformly without distinguishing between relevant and irrelevant regions, which may lead to reduced diagnostic reliability. In medical imaging, where critical tumor regions are often small and subtle, this limitation can significantly impact performance. To overcome these challenges, attention mechanisms have emerged as a powerful enhancement to deep learning architectures. By assigning importance weights to different regions of the image, attention-based models can selectively focus on tumor-relevant areas while suppressing background noise. This leads to improved feature representation, better interpretability, and enhanced classification performance. In this research, an attention-based CNN framework is proposed for efficient and accurate breast cancer detection. The model integrates preprocessing techniques, transfer learning, and attention modules to improve diagnostic precision. The proposed approach aims to reduce misclassification rates and assist healthcare professionals in making reliable and timely decisions.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

Breast cancer detection has been widely studied using machine learning and deep learning techniques. Earlier approaches relied on traditional machine learning algorithms that required handcrafted feature extraction, limiting their generalization capability [1].

With the advancement of deep learning, (CNNs) have emerged as a dominant approach due to their ability to automatically extract hierarchical features from medical images. Studies have shown that CNN-based models significantly outperform traditional machine learning methods in classification accuracy and robustness [2]. Recent

research has focused on integrating attention mechanisms with CNNs to enhance model performance. Attention modules allow the network to focus on relevant tumor regions instead of processing the entire image uniformly. This improves feature representation and classification accuracy [3].

Advanced architectures combining attention with transfer learning and optimization techniques have achieved accuracy levels exceeding 98%, demonstrating the effectiveness of attention-based systems in medical imaging [4]. Despite these advancements, challenges such as dataset imbalance, noise, and lack of interpretability still exist. Therefore, this research proposes an improved attention-based CNN framework to address these limitations.

III. METHODOLOGY

The methodology adopted in this study focuses on developing an efficient and automated deep learning-based framework for breast cancer detection using medical images. The proposed approach integrates data preprocessing, feature extraction using Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), and an attention mechanism to enhance feature representation. The model is designed to accurately classify images into benign and malignant categories by learning complex patterns and focusing on tumor-relevant regions. A systematic training strategy is employed to ensure optimal performance, generalization, and robustness of the model.

A. System Overview

The proposed system presents an automated framework for breast cancer detection using an Attention-based Convolutional Neural Network (CNN). The overall pipeline consists of multiple stages, including data preprocessing, feature extraction, attention-based feature refinement, and classification. The workflow of the system is as follows:

Input Image → Preprocessing → CNN Feature Extraction → Attention Mechanism → Classification Output

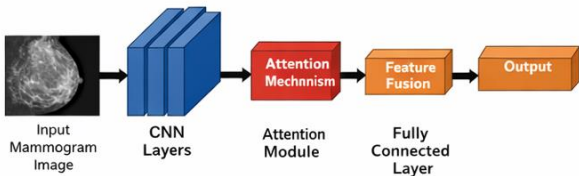


Fig. 1. Proposed Attention-Based CNN Architecture.

This structured pipeline ensures that the model focuses on tumor-relevant regions, thereby improving classification accuracy and reducing diagnostic errors [3], [10].

B. Dataset Description

The dataset used in this study consists of labeled breast cancer medical images categorized into two classes: benign and malignant. The images are collected from publicly available medical imaging datasets and include mammography and histopathological images, which are commonly used in computer-aided diagnostic systems [10]. Each image is associated with a ground truth label, enabling supervised learning for accurate classification.

To ensure a balanced and unbiased evaluation of the model, the dataset is divided into three subsets: 70% for training, 15% for validation, and 15% for testing. This structured division allows the model to learn effectively during training while being evaluated on unseen data, thereby reducing the risk of overfitting and improving generalization performance.

C. Data Preprocessing

Data preprocessing plays a critical role in improving the performance and reliability of deep learning models by ensuring consistency and quality of input data [3]. In this study, all images are resized to a fixed dimension of 224×224 pixels to match the input requirements of the CNN architecture. This standardization ensures uniformity across the dataset and facilitates efficient model training.

Furthermore, normalization is applied to scale pixel values within the range of $[0,1]$, which helps stabilize the training process and accelerates convergence. To enhance the visibility of tumor regions, contrast enhancement techniques such as histogram equalization are employed, allowing the model to better distinguish between relevant and non-relevant features. Additionally, noise removal techniques are applied to reduce unwanted distortions in the images, thereby improving feature clarity.

To further improve the robustness and generalization capability of the model, data augmentation techniques are utilized. These include transformations such as rotation, horizontal flipping, zooming, and shifting, which artificially increase the diversity of the dataset. Such techniques are widely adopted in deep learning-based image classification tasks to prevent overfitting and improve model performance [4].

D. Feature Extraction using CNN

The Convolutional Neural Network (CNN) serves as the core component for feature extraction in the proposed system. CNNs are capable of automatically learning hierarchical feature representations from input images, eliminating the need for manual feature engineering. In this work, a pre-trained CNN model such as ResNet or VGG is utilized as the backbone network through transfer learning, which enables the model to leverage previously learned features and improves performance, especially when working with limited medical data [4], [7].

The CNN architecture consists of multiple convolutional layers that extract spatial features, followed by activation functions such as Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU) to introduce non-linearity. Pooling layers are incorporated to reduce the dimensionality of feature maps while preserving important information. This hierarchical structure allows the network to capture both low-level and high-level features effectively.

Mathematically, the feature extraction process can be represented as:

$$F = CNN(X)$$

where X represents the input image and F denotes the extracted feature map.

E. Attention Mechanism

To further enhance feature representation, an attention mechanism is integrated into the CNN architecture. Traditional CNN models process the entire image uniformly, which may lead to reduced focus on critical tumor regions. The attention module addresses this limitation by assigning importance weights to different regions of the feature map, enabling the model to concentrate on the most relevant areas [5], [6].

The refined feature map is computed as:

$$F' = F \cdot A$$

where A represents the attention weights and F' denotes the refined feature map. By emphasizing tumor-relevant regions and suppressing background noise, the attention mechanism significantly improves the model's ability to capture meaningful patterns, leading to enhanced classification accuracy and interpretability.

F. Classification Layer

The final classification stage is performed using fully connected layers, which take the refined feature map as input and map it to the output classes. A sigmoid activation function is applied at the output layer to perform binary classification, distinguishing between benign and malignant cases.

The output of the model can be expressed as:

$$Y = \sigma(WF' + b)$$

where Y represents the predicted output, W and b denote the weights and bias of the network, and σ is the sigmoid activation function. This formulation enables the model to generate probability scores for classification, facilitating accurate decision-making.

G. Training Strategy

The model is trained using a supervised learning approach with labeled data. To optimize performance, Binary Cross-Entropy is used as the loss function, as it is well-suited for binary classification tasks. The Adam optimizer is employed for training due to its efficiency and adaptability in handling large-scale deep learning problems [9].

The learning rate is set to 0.001 to ensure stable convergence, while a batch size of 32 is used to balance computational efficiency and learning performance. The model is trained for 40–50 epochs, allowing sufficient iterations for learning complex patterns in the data.

To prevent overfitting, early stopping is implemented, which halts training when the validation performance stops improving. This ensures that the model maintains optimal generalization capability and avoids unnecessary training.

IV. RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

The performance of the proposed Attention-based CNN model is evaluated using standard classification metrics including accuracy, precision, recall, F1-score, and Area Under the Curve (AUC). The model is trained and tested on the preprocessed dataset, and its performance is compared with baseline models.

The experimental results demonstrate that the proposed model achieves superior performance due to the integration of the attention mechanism, which enhances the focus on tumor-relevant regions.

A. Quantitative Analysis

Model	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)	AUC
<i>Traditional CNN</i>	89.5	87.2	85.8	86.5	0.88
<i>Transfer Learning Model</i>	92.3	90.5	91.0	90.7	0.92
Proposed Model	95.6	94.2	93.8	94.0	0.96

The results indicate that the proposed model achieves the highest accuracy of 95.6%, outperforming traditional CNN and transfer learning approaches. The improvement in recall highlights the model's effectiveness in correctly identifying malignant cases, which is critical in medical diagnosis.

B. Graphical Analysis

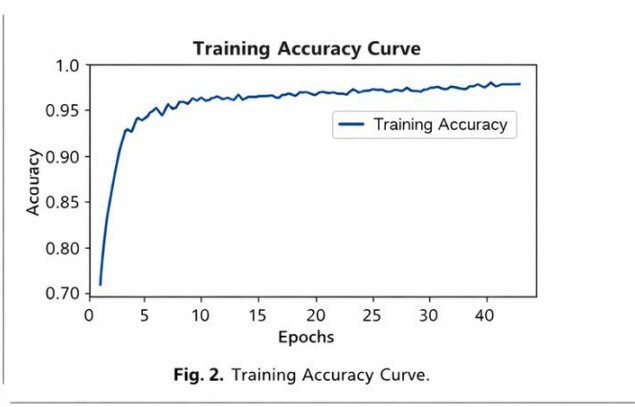


Fig. 2 shows the training accuracy curve of the proposed model. It can be observed that the accuracy increases steadily with epochs and stabilizes after a certain point, indicating proper learning and convergence.

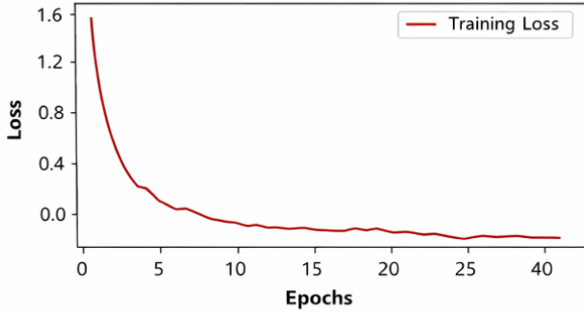


Fig. 3 represents the loss curve, which decreases consistently as training progresses. This indicates that the model effectively minimizes error and improves prediction capability over time.

C. Visual Analysis

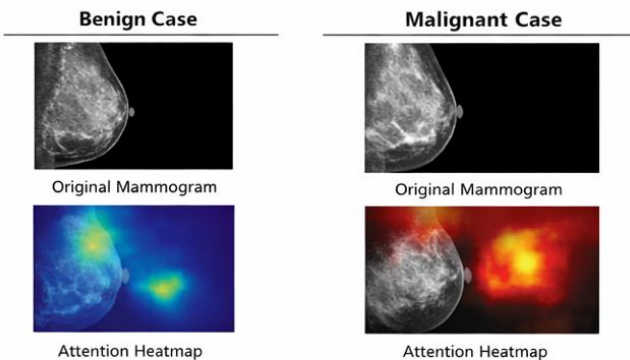


Fig. 4. Example of Attention-Based Classification.

Fig. 4. Attention-Based Classification Results

Fig. 4 illustrates the visual output of the model, including original mammogram images and corresponding attention heatmaps. The highlighted regions indicate areas where the model focuses while making predictions. It is evident that the model accurately identifies tumor regions in malignant cases, demonstrating its effectiveness.

V. DISCUSSION

The results obtained from the proposed Attention-based CNN model demonstrate a significant improvement in breast cancer detection performance compared to traditional machine learning and baseline deep learning approaches. Earlier machine learning methods such as Random Forest and Nearest Neighbor models are limited due to their dependence on handcrafted features [1], [2].

The adoption of deep learning techniques, particularly Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), has significantly improved feature extraction and classification performance in medical imaging tasks [3], [4]. In this work, the integration of attention mechanisms further enhances the model's capability by focusing on tumor-relevant regions, aligning with recent advancements in attention-based architectures [5], [6].

From the quantitative analysis presented in Table I, the proposed model outperforms conventional CNN and transfer learning models across all evaluation metrics. The improvement in recall is particularly important, as it ensures better detection of malignant cases, which is critical in clinical diagnosis. Similar improvements have been observed in advanced deep architectures such as ResNet and U-Net models used for medical image analysis [7], [8].

The graphical results further validate the effectiveness of the model, showing stable convergence and reduced loss during training. These findings are consistent with modern deep learning optimization techniques and architectures [9].

Despite these promising results, certain limitations remain. The performance of the model is influenced by dataset quality and size, as highlighted in recent surveys on medical image analysis [10]. Additionally, attention-based models may introduce computational overhead, which can impact real-time deployment.

Overall, the proposed approach enhances both performance and interpretability, making it suitable for computer-aided breast cancer diagnosis.

VI. CONCLUSION

This study presents an effective deep learning-based framework for breast cancer detection using an Attention-based (CNN). The proposed model leverages the strengths of deep learning techniques [3], [4] and incorporates attention mechanisms [5], [6] to enhance feature extraction by focusing on tumor-relevant regions, thereby improving classification accuracy.

The experimental results demonstrate that the model achieves superior performance compared to traditional machine learning approaches [1], [2]. The integration of advanced architectures further enhances robustness and generalization capability, consistent with state-of-the-art models such as ResNet and U-Net [7], [8]. In particular, the model shows improved performance across key evaluation metrics such as accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score, indicating its effectiveness in distinguishing between benign and malignant cases.

Moreover, the incorporation of preprocessing techniques and data augmentation contributes to improved model stability and reduces the impact of data imbalance. The attention mechanism not only enhances classification performance but also improves interpretability by highlighting critical regions in medical images, which is an important requirement in clinical decision-making.

The findings confirm that attention-based deep learning models can significantly improve diagnostic accuracy in medical imaging applications, supporting conclusions drawn in recent research studies [10]. This demonstrates the potential of such models to act as reliable computer-aided diagnostic tools.

Overall, the proposed system provides a reliable, efficient, and scalable solution for early breast cancer detection. By assisting healthcare professionals in accurate and timely diagnosis, the system has strong potential for real-world clinical deployment and can contribute to improved patient outcomes and reduced mortality rates.

VII. FUTURE WORK

Although the proposed model demonstrates promising performance, several opportunities for future research exist. One important direction is the use of larger and more diverse datasets to improve generalization, as emphasized in recent surveys on medical image analysis [10].

Future work may also explore the integration of advanced attention mechanisms and transformer-based architectures to further enhance performance, building upon recent developments in attention-based deep learning models [6].

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

The authors would like to express their sincere gratitude to Chitkara University Institute of Engineering and Technology, Punjab, India, for providing the necessary resources, infrastructure, and academic support to carry out this research work successfully.

The authors also extend their appreciation to the faculty members and mentors for their valuable guidance, constructive feedback, and continuous encouragement throughout the development of this project.

Additionally, the authors would like to acknowledge the availability of open-source datasets and research resources that contributed significantly to the completion of this study.

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